Subsequently, for a brief period, the word doubled as a synonym for ‘new’, thereby bringing in the element of time. In other words, the word ‘modern’ was not only a reference to the time that something belonged to, it was also importantly a reference to the period it did *not* belong to. Seed revealed that around the early fourteenth century, ‘modern’ was significantly used in Dante’s *Divine Comedy*, wherein it was a synonym for ‘contemporary’. It was used to compare the present with the past, with the present faring poorly, making the use of ‘modern’ a veiled criticism of the present. According to Seed, it was only almost a century later, around the 1430s, that ‘modern’ was used in Southern Romance languages to show the past in poor light and congratulate the present.

As for English, Scottish poet William Dunbar is credited for using it first in his poems, wherein ‘modern’ was used to portray the present in positive light while remaining tight-lipped about the past. The adversarial pitting of the past and the present with the balance tilting in favour of the latter occurred in English in the sixteenth century when ‘modern’ meant ‘someone who takes part in the tastes and cares of his age, and is opposed to all conservatism’. In a nutshell, positive connotations, such as open-mindedness, newness and relevance, were imputed to ‘modern’, and negative stereotypes, such as parochiality, outdatedness and rigidity, were associated with ‘conservative/traditional’. That this imputation coincided with the period around which European powers had established colonies across the globe was no coincidence. This is evidenced from the established nexus between coloniality and ‘modernity’, both of which are undergirded by notions of anthropological superiority, as articulated by Quijano.

Quijano identified that the process of classification of the world on racial lines by the European coloniser led to sub-humanisation and dehumanisation of several communities depending on their perceived worth in the eyes of the coloniser. The ramifications of such a classification included geographic identities acquiring racial connotations, specific skin tones being associated with the respective races of the coloniser and the colonised, and the creation of a new structure of division of labour and resources. Each of these strands ultimately contributed to the creation of serfdoms and slavery, notions of master (or superior) and slave (inferior) races, and notions of the ‘manifest destiny’ of some to rule over others and the fate of others to be perpetually ruled. Lines were drawn between the West and the East, the ‘civilised’ and the ‘primitive’, the scientific and the